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Interdisciplinary HCI

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HyPhy: Unveiling Natural Selection through Computation

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I. Introduction

A. Mutations

Mutations. How does pop culture portray mutations? They can occur when a radioactive spider bites a person, or when some radioactive perturbation inherently changes "something" in a human (or even a turtle). What do mutations do in those contexts? The character gains a new superhuman ability. Why is that surprising? Well, the expectation is that a venomous spider bite should either kill a human or not kill them, certainly not make one superhuman. While the superhuman ability is celebrated, there is always something lonely about these new superheroes because with power comes responsibility. What I am trying to get at is this: despite the celebration of superpowers, the word mutant itself is generally perceived negatively by people.

In biology, mutations happen very frequently, and are not necessarily good or bad—they are simply changes. As you can imagine from the spider-bite and radioactive perturbation examples, a mutation is a change that can give rise to a new function—or a superpower. Surely, being able to detect the bitterness in broccoli when a poisonous plant of a similar flavor is nearby would have been a superpower for someone who needed to forage for food. Mutation is the very mechanism that has made each of us unique.

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